

HELL'S TALES

SIX TESTIMONIES FROM BELOW

AN INFERNAL ANTHOLOGY



Truth does not promise comfort. It promises an account.

A NOTE AT THE THRESHOLD

READ BEFORE DESCENDING

These tales concern non-conventional religious beliefs and points of view. Some readers may find the material offensive, dangerous, or irreverent. Enter with an open mind only if you can tolerate an alternative narrative to traditional Christian teaching. These stories are written for the free thinker who believes a painful truth is worth more than a comfortable lie that preserves willful ignorance.

This is fiction. Its tribunals, devils, saints, records, and punishments are instruments of moral inquiry—not articles of faith.

THE DESCENT

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Six witnesses. Six accounts. No innocence purchased with another person's pain.



TESTIMONY I

THE BARGAIN



AN ACCOUNT ENTERED WITHOUT APPEAL



The man arrived in Hell with his hands folded as if he had been expecting an appointment.

He expected claws. He expected horns. He expected the kind of vulgar spectacle he had purchased for other men in paintings and sermons. Instead, he found a narrow room, a black table, and a figure in an elegant suit turning the pages of a ledger.

The figure did not look up.

“Before the end,” it said, “what did you ask for?”

The man smiled. He had spent a lifetime surviving questions by answering the questioner instead.

“A name would help.”

“Yours will be sufficient.”

The ledger opened by itself. Millions of names moved across its pages like ants fleeing a fire. Beside every name stood a promise. Beside every promise stood a price.

His own name appeared in the center of the page.

Lucian Voss had been called generous by men who needed his favor and ruthless by men who had lost it. Neither word pleased him. Generosity suggested weakness. Ruthlessness suggested appetite. He preferred disciplined. He had inherited three factories, acquired nine more, purchased a newspaper, a senator, two bishops, and enough public affection to make all four arrangements respectable.

“I asked for nothing,” Lucian said. “I built what I possessed.”

The figure finally raised its eyes. They were ordinary eyes, gray and tired.

“Then this will be brief.”

It turned the ledger toward him. The first promise had been made when Lucian was nine. His father lay dying above a kitchen in winter. Lucian had knelt beside the bed and promised any listening power that he would never



again be helpless. The room remembered his exact words, including the ones he had forgotten.

Take tenderness, he had whispered. Take sleep. Take everyone before they can leave me. Only do not let me become small.

“A child’s fear is not a contract,” Lucian said.

“Correct.”

The entry vanished.

Relief warmed him. “Then you admit the error.”

“I admit your first petition carried no price. What followed was your own work.”

The wall behind the figure opened onto a mill floor. Women stood at looms beneath windows blackened by coal. A boy reached into a machine while the belt still moved. Lucian recognized the room. He had toured it once. He had complained that the workers stared.

“Industrial necessity,” he said.

The boy’s hand disappeared between the gears. The sound was small. That was what Lucian remembered now. Not the scream, but the small sound before it.

The ledger recorded a meeting held the following morning. Compensation had been denied because the boy’s mother could not prove the child had been instructed to clean the teeth while the machine was still.

“I did not write that rule.”

“No. You approved the man who did.”

The next page showed a river carrying red dye past a village well. Another showed police breaking a line of hungry workers. Another showed a widow signing away her house beneath the gaze of Lucian’s attorney. In each account, his hand was distant. In each account, his profit arrived clean.

Lucian began to understand the room. “This is an accusation.”

“It is an inventory.”



“Where is my advocate?”

“You employed them all.”

The black door opened. His chief counsel entered carrying a leather case. Harrow had died twelve years earlier and looked healthier than Lucian remembered.

“At last,” Lucian said.

Harrow placed the case on the table and took the chair beside him. “I have been retained by the opposing interests.”

“With what money?”

“None. They paid me with memory.”

The case contained every contract Harrow had drawn for Lucian. The language remained crisp. The consequences bled through it. A harmless paragraph smelled of a family sleeping beneath a bridge. A signature line coughed with the lungs of miners. An indemnity clause contained the final thoughts of thirty-seven passengers on a ferry built from rejected steel.

Lucian pushed the papers away. “All commerce has consequences.”

“Yes,” said the figure. “That is why commerce is counted.”

“I gave millions to hospitals.”

A second ledger appeared. It was thinner. His charities were entered there without mockery: the fever ward, the orphan school, the bread kitchens, the scholarships carrying his name. Lucian leaned closer.

“You see.”

“We see everything.”

Each gift bore another column. The fever ward had been built after his mills poisoned the river. The orphan school housed children whose fathers had died in his mines. The bread kitchens opened during the strike he prolonged. Even so, some good remained. A girl had learned medicine. A sick man had lived long enough to reconcile with his son. A cook had stolen bread from the kitchen and fed a street Lucian never knew existed.



“Those lives belong to my account.”

The figure shook its head. “You wish to own the mercy of people who repaired what you broke.”

For the first time, Lucian struck the table. The room trembled, but the figure did not.

“What bargain do you want?” he asked.

“The one you always wanted. Your suffering can be transferred.”

Lucian became still.

Six people were brought into the room. His wife. His eldest son. Harrow. The bishop whose cathedral bore his mother’s name. The mill foreman. Last came an old woman in a patched coat. Lucian did not recognize her.

“Choose one,” said the figure. “That soul will serve your sentence. You may depart.”

Harrow stared at the floor. The bishop began to pray. Lucian’s son wept with the embarrassed silence he had learned at boarding school. His wife only watched him.

Lucian’s mind resumed its old work. Harrow had profited. The foreman had enforced. The bishop had blessed. His son had squandered. His wife had known. Any one of them could be made responsible without changing the facts very much.

“Who is she?” he asked, pointing to the old woman.

The figure read from the ledger. “Marta Elian. Her husband died in your eastern mine. Her daughter died in the fever ward. Her grandson was the boy at the gears.”

“Why is she here?”

“To make the offer complete.”

The old woman stepped forward. “Choose me.”

Lucian distrusted willingness. “Why?”



“Because then you will leave.”

He almost laughed. “You forgive me?”

“No. I want to see whether there is anywhere you can go where you are not yourself.”

The sentence struck deeper than accusation. Lucian studied the faces before him and discovered that every choice was familiar. His life had been one long room in which another person stood between him and cost. The bargain was not Hell’s invention. Hell had merely removed the paperwork.

“If I refuse?”

“You will serve what belongs to you.”

“For how long?”

“Until you can feel a consequence without converting it into a number.”

Lucian looked again at Marta. Her hands were knotted with age. He imagined those hands inside the machinery of his sentence. He imagined the door opening. He imagined daylight, or whatever passed for it after death.

“I choose—”

His wife closed her eyes. His son bent at the waist. Harrow waited like a clerk beside a signature.

Lucian stopped.

The old childhood prayer returned to him: Take everyone before they can leave me.

He understood at last that it had been answered. Not by a demon, but by every choice he had made afterward.

“I choose my account,” he said.

The figure closed the ledger.

The mill floor rose around him. The belt moved. The river darkened. Thirty-seven passengers called from cold water. He felt no flame. He felt each distance disappear.



Marta watched until he began to scream. Then she turned to the suited figure.

“Will he learn?”

“Every soul learns,” it said. “The question is what remains when the lesson is no longer avoidable.”

The door opened for her.

Behind them, Lucian Voss received the first thing he had ever truly purchased.

He received the price.



TESTIMONY II

THE PIOUS



AN ACCOUNT ENTERED WITHOUT APPEAL



The bishop died beneath a ceiling painted with angels.

His followers filled the cathedral for the funeral. They praised his certainty, his discipline, and the way his voice made doubt seem like a disease from which only obedience could save them. He entered the next world wearing the same small, confident smile carved into the memorial prepared before his death.

Then the light changed.

He stood in a corridor lined with church doors. Behind each door waited the face of someone he had corrected, shamed, exiled, silenced, or used as proof of his own goodness.

A clerk in ash-colored robes offered him a form.

“State your name as you gave it to the poor,” she said, “not as you printed it on the building.”

“Bishop Aurelius Vane.”

The clerk waited.

“His Excellency, the Most Reverend—”

“The poor did not call you that.”

He remembered the bread line behind Saint Orison’s. The people there called him Your Grace when cameras were present. When the cameras left, he entered through another door.

“Father,” he said.

The form remained blank.

The first door opened. A young woman sat inside a bare room holding a dead infant. Aurelius knew her only after she spoke.

“You called me impure.”

Lena Marr had come to him at seventeen, pregnant by a deacon whose name the bishop removed from the inquiry. The church had sent the deacon elsewhere and sent Lena away. Her child died during the winter.



“I upheld the teaching,” Aurelius said.

The clerk made a mark. “You have named the shield. We asked for the hand.”

Door after door opened. Brother Tomas, who confessed doubt and lost his parish. Elias Crow, who slept on the cathedral steps while an empty rectory stood heated. Sister Amabel, whose research Aurelius published beneath his own name. A choirboy who had told the truth about a beloved priest and learned how quickly holy men could call truth a scandal.

Aurelius supplied reasons for each. Doctrine. Order. Prudence. The protection of the faithful. He had used these words so often they came polished.

At the corridor’s end stood a chapel smaller than a closet. Inside waited an altar, a basin, and a single chair.

“You may wash,” said the clerk.

The bishop plunged his hands into the basin. The water blackened.

“Again.”

He washed until the skin split. The water grew darker.

“This is blasphemous theater.”

“No. Theater requires an audience that can be deceived.”

The wall behind the altar brightened. Aurelius saw his cathedral during the years of his rule. He saw himself blessing the homeless at Christmas, then ordering iron spikes placed beneath the portico in January. He saw letters from desperate families stacked unopened beneath a silver reliquary. He saw the private dining room where he discussed humility over wine that cost more than a laborer’s year.

Yet the vision also showed what he had forgotten: nights beside dying parishioners, a scholarship quietly paid, a frightened child carried from a flood. He reached toward these memories.

“There. You see I served.”



"You did," said the clerk.

The admission confused him more than condemnation.

"Then why am I here?"

"Because good deeds do not become currency with which cruelty is purchased."

Another figure entered the chapel. She wore the plain dress of an old sacristan. Aurelius recognized Mother Sabine, who had taught him before ambition taught him better lessons.

"You told me pride was the first sin," he said.

"I told you pride begins when a man mistakes his office for his soul."

She placed his mitre on the altar. It had grown enormous, crusted with gold, too heavy for any neck.

"The faithful needed symbols."

"They needed courage," Sabine replied. "You taught them dependence and called it faith."

The chapel doors vanished. In their place stood the congregation from his funeral. Thousands listened as a recording of his final sermon filled the corridor. He had preached that suffering was a gate God opened for those He loved.

Lena's dead child cried behind the words.

"Stop this."

The clerk handed him a key. "You may stop one voice. Choose."

The sermon continued. So did the infant. Around them rose every prayer Aurelius had ignored because answering it would inconvenience someone powerful.

He chose the recording of himself.

The key dissolved.



Silence did not follow. Without his voice, he could hear the others clearly.

For a long time he knelt. He began with Lena's name. Then Tomas. Elias. Amabel. The choirboy, whose name he had trained himself not to remember.

"Jonas," said the clerk.

"Jonas."

With each name, a church door opened. Behind none waited torture. There waited only the life he had refused to imagine. He felt hunger without the lesson he once attached to it. Shame without the sermon. Loneliness without the promise that it improved the lonely.

When the last door opened, Aurelius was no longer wearing vestments. He stood in the thin nightclothes of the old man who had died beneath painted angels.

"Am I damned?" he asked.

"You came asking for a kingdom where every person knew his place," said Sabine. "You have found it."

The cathedral appeared around him. Its nave was full, but the pulpit stood at floor level. The people he had silenced sat above him in the galleries. Before him lay no prepared text.

"What must I preach?"

"Nothing."

The clerk removed his ring. Sabine removed his cross. Lena placed the dead child in his arms.

"Listen," she said.

The bishop held the weight he had reduced to doctrine. The congregation began to speak, one soul at a time. They did not speak forever. It only seemed so because Aurelius had never allowed them a minute.



At last the infant opened its eyes. The bishop looked down and saw no accusation there, only a question too simple for theology.

What did you do with the power you were given?

Aurelius bowed his uncovered head.

For the first time in his long and pious life, he had no answer prepared.

That was the beginning of his confession.



TESTIMONY III

THE ACCUSER



AN ACCOUNT ENTERED WITHOUT APPEAL



The summons was written in light.

It burned through Satan's desk, the stack of unfinished indictments beneath it, and the hand of the messenger who delivered it. The messenger did not complain. Angels had been trained to regard pain as proof that an order mattered.

Satan read the first line and sighed.

"Again?"

The Court Above had charged humanity with another century of crimes. War. Famine. Cruelty made efficient. Faith converted into permission. The prosecution had assembled mountains of evidence and left one chair empty.

The chair was for the Accuser.

Satan arrived without horns. This disappointed the gallery. He wore a dark coat and carried the ruined summons folded in his pocket. Above the bench hung a sun that gave light without warmth.

The Presiding Virtue spoke with seven mouths. "You are called to testify concerning the corruption of humankind."

"I am called whenever Heaven wants a second signature."

Murmurs moved among the saints. The chief prosecutor unfurled a scroll across the floor. It ran through the doors and down the stairs beyond sight.

"Do you deny tempting them?"

"Often."

"Do you deny teaching them disobedience?"

"Proudly."

"Do you deny your hand in murder, conquest, greed, and desecration?"

Satan examined the empty chair before sitting. "Which hand?"

The first witness was a king who had burned twelve cities while priests sang behind him. He pointed at Satan.

"He filled me with ambition."



“You sent me away three times,” Satan said.

The king blinked.

“The first time, I suggested you spare the eastern city so its rebellion would shame your father. You called mercy cowardice. The second, I offered you a dream in which your enemy’s children carried your name. You ordered their deaths before breakfast. The third, I stopped speaking. You seemed to have mastered the craft.”

The prosecutor objected. “The witness could not know the source of his thoughts.”

“Then why was he permitted to blame me for them?”

The court recorded the question and sealed it where no one could answer.

Next came a merchant who starved a province. Then an inquisitor. Then a mother who taught her son to hate strangers and wept when the hatred returned wearing a uniform. Each named a whisper, a shadow, an influence. Satan remembered some of them. Others he had never met.

At noon the Presiding Virtue called a recess. Satan walked onto a balcony overlooking Creation. From that height, suffering appeared orderly. Smoke rose in straight lines. Graves resembled punctuation.

An angel joined him. The messenger’s burned hand had healed.

“Why do you defend them?” the angel asked.

“I do not.”

“You dispute every charge.”

“I dispute the convenience.”

Below, a child stole bread. A magistrate sentenced him. A wealthy woman praised the law. None required supernatural instruction.

“If they are free,” Satan said, “their crimes belong to them. If they are not, the crimes belong to their maker. Heaven cannot have both conclusions merely because both are useful.”

The angel looked afraid. “That is not permitted reasoning.”



“It is the only kind worth permitting.”

When court resumed, Satan called his own witnesses. The prosecutor protested that the Accuser had no right to mount a defense.

“I am not defending humanity,” Satan said. “I am indicting authorship.”

He called Silence first. It entered as an empty robe. Silence had stood in camps, bedrooms, prisons, and churches while victims begged for any sign that the universe objected.

He called Obedience. It arrived wearing every uniform ever blessed.

He called Certainty, blindfolded and carrying a torch.

Last he called a nameless woman from a ruined city. She had lost her family in a war fought by men who claimed both Heaven and Hell desired it. Still, she had hidden an enemy child beneath her floor.

“Who tempted you to mercy?” Satan asked.

“No one.”

“Who commanded it?”

“No one.”

“Why did you act?”

“The child was afraid.”

Satan turned to the bench. “There is your corruption. A creature capable of uncommanded mercy is also capable of uncommanded cruelty.”

The seven mouths conferred. The sun above them dimmed.

“What judgment do you seek?”

“Accuracy.”

The word unsettled the court.

Satan removed from his coat a book bound in scorched leather. It contained every deed attributed to him. He opened it and began returning the entries. A massacre moved to a general’s account. A betrayal moved to a



friend's. A doctrine of hatred moved to the theologian who composed it and the congregations that enjoyed repeating it. Page by page, the book grew lighter while humanity's record grew honest.

Not innocent. Honest.

When he finished, only a few entries remained: questions planted, doors opened, forbidden fruit named forbidden so that desire could recognize itself.

"You admit these?" asked the Virtue.

"Every one."

"Then you are still the Accuser."

Satan stood. "No. I was the first witness for the defense."

The gallery erupted. Saints shouted. Kings demanded their excuses back. The prosecutor tore the scroll, but each fragment continued to speak.

The nameless woman approached Satan as the court dissolved into argument.

"Will they punish you?"

"They already did."

"For what?"

He looked toward the high sun, beautiful and cold.

"For asking whether worship given under threat could be called love."

The woman considered this. "What happens to us now?"

"You will be judged."

"By Hell?"

"Hell judges no soul. It carries out the sentence that truth makes necessary."

Behind the bench, a crack appeared in the light. Through it came the voices of the dead, no longer willing to let demons take credit for what human beings had done.



Satan offered the woman his arm.

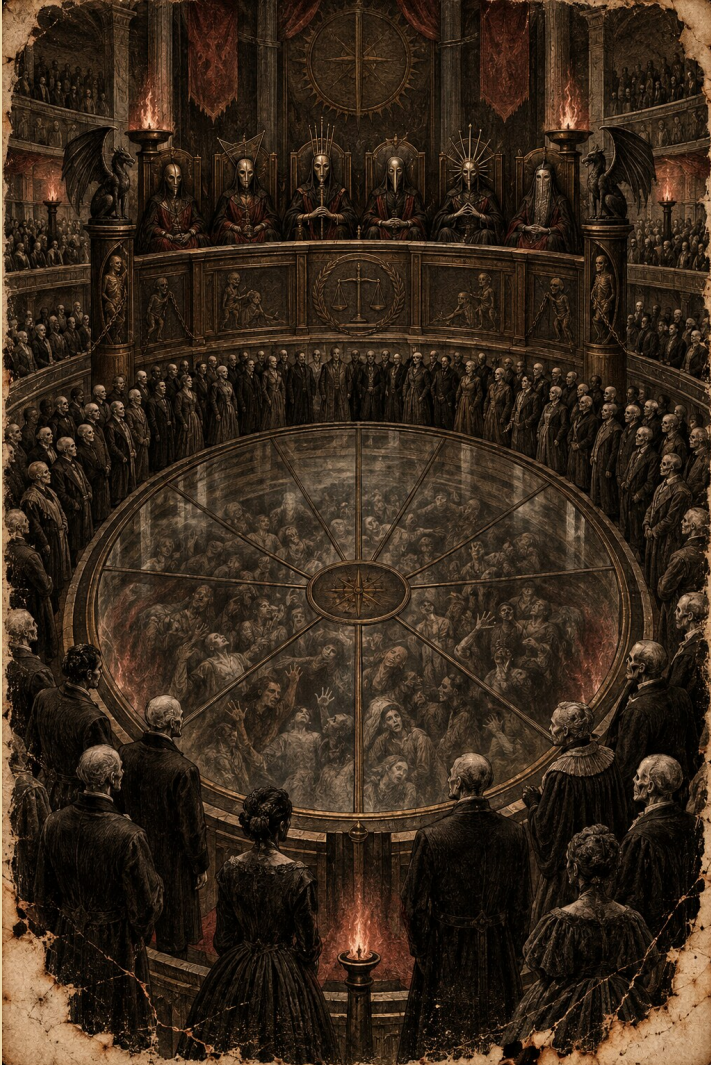
“Come,” he said. “The difficult testimony is about to begin.”

And for the first time since accusation was invented, the empty chair belonged to Heaven.



TESTIMONY IV

THE TRIBUNAL



AN ACCOUNT ENTERED WITHOUT APPEAL



The congregation died together.

The roof collapsed during the final hymn, burying the faithful beneath stone saints and splintered beams. They arrived below still arranged in rows, still looking toward the front for someone with authority to explain the delay.

No one came.

The benches on which they sat were witness stands. Around them rose thirteen tiers of dark seats. At the center lay a circle of smoked glass showing the faces of people they had prayed for publicly and abandoned privately.

A voice moved through the chamber.

“Titles are surrendered. Excuses will be heard. None will be presumed true.”

Reverend Pell stood first. Death had left dust in his hair and a hymnbook crushed against his chest.

“My flock acted in good faith.”

Six judges entered from six doors. Their faces changed whenever the congregation blinked: child, widow, stranger, enemy, beloved, self. Behind them came seven Persecutors carrying iron hooks shaped like questions. Thirteen Witnesses occupied the first tier. Six hundred thirty-nine Jurors filled the rest. No two looked in the same direction.

At the circle’s edge waited the Sentencer, veiled and silent.

“Who is accused?” Pell asked.

The smoked glass brightened beneath every bench.

“Whoever recognizes himself.”

The first case concerned the winter shelter. The congregation had raised money, posed for photographs, and closed it after neighbors complained that poverty lowered property values. A man named Abram had frozen behind their fellowship hall.

Pell raised his Bible. “We did what resources allowed.”



One Persecutor hooked the word resources from his mouth. It hung in the air, opened, and spilled receipts for new stained glass.

The Jurors made no sound. Their silence weighed more than outrage.

Next came Mara Finch, who led the women's charity. She had visited the sick and carried casseroles to every funeral. She had also spread a rumor about a young mother until the woman fled town.

"I was concerned for the children."

A hook removed concerned. Inside it crawled pleasure.

Mara screamed that this was unfair. The judges changed faces. One became the young mother. Another became Mara at seventeen, weeping after a rumor of her own.

Case followed case. Some were small enough to be forgotten and sharp enough to change a life. A withheld invitation. A prayer request used as gossip. A son condemned for loving the wrong person. A lonely old man treated kindly only while his estate remained undecided.

The congregation began accusing one another. Fingers rose. Alliances formed by pew and family. Every soul believed the sins of the next bench provided useful scale.

The fifth judge rang a cracked bell.

"Comparison is not repentance."

The floor turned transparent. Beneath it waited the church as it had been before the collapse. Rescue crews moved through dust. Outside, reporters interviewed survivors. Deacon Vale, who had stepped out to answer a private call, praised Reverend Pell's leadership. No one knew Pell had approved cheaper repairs after an engineer warned the roof would fail.

The engineer appeared among the Witnesses.

Pell's hymnbook fell open. Inside was the letter. He had kept it to remind himself to act after the building campaign.

"I intended—"



The seventh Persecutor drew intended from him. It was hollow.

The congregation surged away. They had called him shepherd in life. Now they called him murderer.

Pell shouted above them. “You voted for the new organ. You applauded the expansion. You asked me not to alarm anyone.”

The glass reflected all their faces.

For once, he was telling the truth.

The Tribunal recessed. The damned received no water, but thirst was not their suffering. Their suffering was that conversation continued without allowing anyone to leave. Families repeated arguments cut short by death. Friends confessed what they had concealed. Kindnesses emerged beside cruelties, complicating every hatred.

An old woman named Ruth sat alone. She had cleaned the church for forty years and spoken rarely. In life they had mistaken quiet for agreement.

“What do the Jurors decide?” she asked the nearest Witness.

“They do not decide.”

“Then why are they here?”

“To prevent any soul from imagining that consequence has only one observer.”

When the judges returned, Ruth entered the center voluntarily.

The glass showed her leaving food outside Abram’s hiding place after the shelter closed. It also showed her seeing the engineer’s letter on Pell’s desk and saying nothing because she feared losing her employment.

“I was afraid,” she said.

No hook came for the word. It was true.

“Does fear absolve you?”

“No.”

“Does it condemn you?”



Ruth looked at Abram among the Witnesses. "It explains me. It does not repair him."

For the first time, the Sentencer lifted its head.

One by one, the congregation entered the circle. The proceeding lasted beyond clocks. Those who defended every act found their words returned as rooms they could not exit. Those who confessed merely to shorten pain discovered that confession used as a key opened nothing. Those who named harm without bargaining were seated beside the people they harmed and made to hear the part of the story in which they were not the hero.

At last only Reverend Pell remained.

He stood upon the smoked glass. Above him, six Judges watched. Around him, seven Persecutors lowered their hooks. Thirteen Witnesses waited. Six hundred thirty-nine Jurors breathed as one body.

"I failed them," Pell said.

The words lay lifeless.

"I loved the church."

The glass showed stone, organ pipes, his name on a bronze plaque.

"I loved being needed."

The glass warmed.

"I knew the roof was dangerous."

It grew clear.

"I chose the appearance of safety over the cost of truth."

At last he could see beneath it, not the ruined sanctuary but the people as they had been on the morning of their deaths: impatient, tender, vain, frightened, generous, cruel, alive.

The Sentencer removed its veil.

It wore Pell's face.



His sentence was not flame. He would rebuild the sanctuary alone, stone by stone, while feeling the weight of every life lost beneath it. When the roof was sound, the congregation could choose whether to enter. He could not ask them. He could not preach. He could only build.

“How long?” Pell whispered.

Ruth answered from the first tier.

“Until the shelter stays open.”

The Tribunal emptied. The six Judges became doors. The seven Persecutors became keys. The Witnesses departed with their memories intact. The Jurors vanished into the countless places where private choices become public ruin.

Reverend Pell lifted the first stone.

It was heavier than doctrine.



TESTIMONY V

THE FURNACE GOSPEL



AN ACCOUNT ENTERED WITHOUT APPEAL



The book was found in a furnace that had burned for nine hundred years.

Its pages were hot but unconsumed. Its binding had no title, only the impression of two hands pulling in opposite directions. The monks who discovered it carried it to the scriptorium with iron tongs and argued for three days over who had permission to read it.

On the fourth day, the book opened by itself.

Brother Caldus was chosen because he had copied more approved terrors than any living man. His devils had claws. His sinners begged. His flames curled beautifully around the margins.

The first line offended him.

Hell was not made for pain. Hell was made for truth.

“Heretical,” said Abbot Severin, without reading further.

The book turned a page.

Every lie creates the fire required to reveal it.

The abbey had been built over the Furnace Gospel’s chamber. Its monks copied warnings for kings, indulgences for merchants, and histories in which every victorious patron had been favored by God. They called the furnace sacred because it destroyed drafts that contradicted the final version.

Caldus had fed it many pages.

That night he returned alone. The book waited on the lectern. Beside it lay a pen cut from a black feather.

“What do you want copied?” he asked.

The pages filled with his own handwriting.

He saw the Chronicle of Saint Vey, commissioned by Duke Orlan after the duke slaughtered a village. Caldus had changed slaughtered to pacified. He had changed children to insurgents. In the margin, he had painted an angel offering Orlan a crown.

“I copied what the abbot gave me.”



The sentence appeared beneath his defense: A hand does not become innocent because another mouth commands it.

Caldus closed the book. Heat pulsed through the cover.

The next morning, Severin ordered it destroyed. They chained the volume, carried it to the furnace, and threw it into the white center. For a moment the book disappeared. Then every manuscript in the abbey began to smoke.

Words rose from parchment in black ribbons. Saints lost borrowed miracles. Kings recovered their massacres. Martyrs admitted fear. Heretics regained the sentences removed from their testimony. The monks ran through the library beating at truth with wet cloths.

The Gospel lay on the furnace floor, open and unharmed.

“Seal the chamber,” Severin commanded.

They built a wall before sunset. At midnight, letters burned through the stones.

Caldus read them from his cell: CERTAINTY IS THE LAST IDOL BECAUSE IT TEACHES THE WORSHIPPER TO CALL HIS OWN VOICE DIVINE.

By morning, pilgrims had gathered. A shepherd claimed the words cured his blindness. A noble claimed they proved his enemies damned. Merchants sold scraps of scorched cloth. Severin announced that the abbey alone could interpret the sign.

The Gospel wrote another line: Every cage begins as an explanation.

Severin ordered Caldus to produce an authorized copy. **“Remove what invites confusion.”**

“That may be all of it.”

“Then preserve the useful danger and discard the rest.”

Caldus sat before a clean sheet. For three days he could not write. Each time his pen touched parchment, the furnace showed him a face altered by his previous work. A mother whose murdered sons had been renamed insurgents.



A novice expelled for questioning a relic. A prisoner who confessed after reading Caldus's illustrated torments.

On the fourth night, a woman stepped from the heat. Her robe was burned away at the edges, but her skin carried no wound.

"Are you a demon?" Caldus asked.

"Would that make the words false?"

"It would reveal their source."

"Men who cannot answer a statement often examine the speaker."

She called herself Nema, keeper of discarded lines. Beneath the furnace, she said, lay every truth removed to make power appear holy. The Gospel was not one book. It was the pressure of those buried words seeking form.

"Why choose me?"

"You know how beautiful a lie can be when properly illuminated."

Nema led him through the furnace. The flames were cold. Beyond them stretched a library without walls. Books lay in ash, whispering. Caldus found histories written by the defeated, prayers that accused God, testimonies of women dismissed as temptation, discoveries condemned because they arrived before permission.

At the center stood his own unfinished life.

He saw the boy he had been, curious and insolent, asking why an all-knowing God required monks to hide books. He saw Severin strike him. He saw himself learn that safety lived inside approved sentences.

"I was afraid," Caldus said.

"Fear is honest," Nema replied. "What you built from it was not."

When he returned, the abbey was burning. Not with ordinary flame. Every false line glowed red while every honest uncertainty remained black. The monks tore pages apart, desperate to separate obedience from deceit.

Severin stood before the altar holding the authorized copy Caldus had not written.



“Tell them it is a test,” the abbot pleaded. “Tell them faith requires submission.”

“To what?”

“To the Church.”

“You used to say God.”

For one instant, Severin looked old.

Caldus took the black pen. He wrote on the chapel wall: We do not know.

The furnace roared.

The words did not burn.

Some monks fled. Some attacked him. Others sat among the falling ash and began reading pages they had been forbidden to touch. Severin raised a torch to the original Gospel.

Nema caught his wrist.

“You cannot destroy it,” she said.

“Why?”

“Because you are inside it.”

The book opened to its final page. There stood the abbey, the furnace, the pilgrims, the merchants, Caldus with his pen, Severin with his torch. Beneath the image waited a blank line.

Caldus understood. The Gospel did not predict. It demanded authorship.

He wrote: The truth did not save us. It made salvation impossible to counterfeit.

The furnace went dark.

Without its light, dawn entered through the windows. It was weak, gray, and sufficient.



Years later, travelers found the abbey roofless. No official history explained its fall. In the old scriptorium rested a book without a title. Its pages were cool. Anyone could open it, but no two readers found the same words.

At the beginning, however, one warning remained constant:

Read only if you are willing to lose the lie that brought you here.



TESTIMONY VI

THE LAST SERMON



AN ACCOUNT ENTERED WITHOUT APPEAL



The preacher woke at 3:17 in the morning and found a visitor sitting in the chair beside his bed.

“Leave it dark,” the visitor said. “You always preferred me that way.”

Reverend Silas Creed knew the voice. He had invented it for forty years. He had given it laughter, hunger, silk, smoke, and a hatred of children. He had made it whisper through records played backward and wait behind every question a frightened believer was afraid to ask.

“Satan.”

“You got several details wrong.”

Lightning opened the room. For an instant Silas saw no beast, only a grave man with tired eyes and rain on his shoulders.

“Why are you here?”

“Before you meet the people who believed you.”

Silas reached for the lamp. It would not light. His wife slept beside him without breathing, though she was not dead. The clock remained at 3:17.

“This is a dream.”

“That has never prevented you from calling something revelation.”

The visitor placed six cassette tapes on the blanket. Silas recognized the labels. Each held a sermon from a different decade. The Devil in the Nursery. The War Against Doubt. God’s Chosen Nation. The Obedient Wife. The Mark Among Us. The Last Sermon, still unwritten.

“You made a career of my biography,” Satan said. “I thought professional courtesy required a correction.”

The first tape began to play without a machine. Silas’s younger voice filled the room, fierce and bright. He warned a small congregation that doubt opened the soul like a window.

The wall became that church. A twelve-year-old boy listened from the second row. Years later, the boy would hide questions about his own nature until shame became a rope in a garage.



“I never told him to die.”

“No. You only told him what would happen if he lived honestly.”

The second tape played. Silas preached that suffering women must submit with joy. His own daughter Miriam sat in the front pew with a bruise beneath her sleeve. She had come home that night and asked whether God required her to return to her husband.

Silas remembered his answer.

Marriage is a cross.

Miriam returned. Three years later, the husband broke her jaw. Silas paid the hospital bill anonymously and praised forgiveness publicly.

“She survived.”

“You say that as if survival proves the wound was permitted.”

Silas tried to pray. Every holy name came out wearing his own voice.

The visitor leaned forward. “That is your first correction. I did not invent fear. I merely refused to call it faith.”

The third tape contained a rally. Flags hung behind the cross. Silas declared one nation chosen and its enemies instruments of darkness. Young men cheered. Some enlisted. One came home without legs; another did not come home.

“I supported my country.”

“You made God small enough to salute it.”

“People needed certainty.”

“People wanted certainty. You needed their need.”

The room expanded into Silas’s private office. Donation charts covered the walls. Beside each sermon title stood the amount it had raised. Fear performed best. Satan appeared in red ink wherever revenue had fallen.

Silas saw the pattern and hated the neatness of it.

“You think I did no good?”



The visitor shook his head. "That is another detail you got wrong. Hell does not require you to be entirely evil. Only children's stories do."

They watched Silas feed families, comfort widows, build a clinic, sit all night with a dying friend. None was removed. None canceled what followed. His life refused the simplicity he had sold to others.

At 3:17, the bedroom door opened. Miriam entered. She was alive, older now, and carrying the silence that had grown between them.

"Is this really her?" Silas asked.

"It is really what you know of her. The difference should trouble you."

Miriam sat at the foot of the bed. "Why didn't you believe me?"

"I believed you."

"Then why did you send me back?"

He reached for doctrine and found every phrase already used.

"I was afraid the church would divide."

"It did. It divided me from myself."

She vanished when the fourth tape began. On it, Silas described Hell in loving detail. Hooks. Wheels. Lakes of fire. He had noticed early that congregations leaned closer to punishment than grace.

"Were any details correct?" he asked.

"The pain."

"And the flames?"

"Sometimes."

"The demons?"

"Frequently human."

"What happens there?"

"Nothing is hidden well enough to remain harmless."



Silas looked at the blank sixth cassette. "My last sermon."

"You will preach it tomorrow."

"If this is judgment, why send me back?"

"Because a warning after death is only punishment. A warning before death is choice."

The visitor gave him the tape. It was warm.

"What must I say?"

"What you know."

"They will leave."

"Some."

"The ministry will collapse."

"Perhaps."

"My enemies will rejoice."

Satan smiled without kindness. "You still believe truth is valuable only when the right people benefit."

The clock moved to 3:18. His wife drew a breath. The lamp came on.

Silas was alone.

The next morning the sanctuary overflowed. News of his coming retirement had spread. Cameras waited. The choir sang the anthem chosen to summarize his life. Behind the pulpit, the screens displayed photographs: crusades, baptisms, presidents, hospitals, crowds with raised hands.

Silas carried no Bible and no notes. In his pocket lay the blank cassette.

"For forty years," he began, "I have warned you about the father of lies."

The congregation leaned forward.

"I did not tell you how often a lie wears the face of a frightened preacher."



No one moved.

He told them about Miriam. He named the boy from the second row. He described the donation charts, the calculated terrors, the private doubts he had condemned in public. He did not decorate the confession with a story of redemption. He did not ask forgiveness before the wounded had decided whether it belonged to him.

People left. Others shouted. An elder cut the microphone, but Silas continued in the sudden honest quiet.

At the rear doors stood the visitor in the dark coat.

Silas reached the final sentence.

"If God is truth, then every comfortable lie preached in His defense is an accusation against Him."

The visitor bowed his head.

Miriam remained in the front pew. She did not smile. She did not leave.

Afterward, Silas found the cassette in his pocket. A label had appeared in red ink: THE FIRST HONEST SERMON.

He died seven months later, not beneath painted angels or before a cheering crowd, but in Miriam's spare room with the window open.

At 3:17 in the morning, he entered a narrow hall. The people who had believed him waited there. Some held gratitude. Some held injuries. Most held both.

Satan opened the door.

"Am I in Hell?" Silas asked.

"You are where your words became lives."

"How long must I stay?"

"Until you have listened to every sermon you made another person live."

Silas stepped inside.

For the first time, no pulpit stood between him and the congregation.



He took an empty chair.

And the last sermon began.

END OF TESTIMONY

THE RECORD REMAINS OPEN

The cover engraving and six chapter plates are reusable companion artwork created for this edition. The separate image files are included beside the finished PDF.

